

URBAN RECONSTRUCTION TECHNICAL WORKING GROUP (UR-TWG)

Session I

13th November 2019, HRRP Office, Lalitpur

14:00-16:00

AGENDA

- I. Recapping urban recovery and sharing of POs experiences
- II. Urban issues: approaches on prioritization
- III. Discussing NRA's proposal and embedding it into UR-TWG's strategy
- IV. Distribution of tasks and way forward

ATTENDEES

Lumanti, JICA, Kathmandu Metropolitan City, CRS, NSET and HRRP.
(Detailed list of participants in the Appendix)

KEY POINTS

The session followed the above-mentioned agenda through a presentation[S1] .

Presentation summary:

- History of work done by HRRP in collaboration with NRA on urban reconstruction. The focus on urban recovery has been fairly recent. There was an experience sharing session on 23rd October 2019, which led to the formation of this UR-TWG
- Recognizing the need to collectively prioritize urban issues. Inviting the members to help expand and edit the list of urban issues
- Discussing what is NRA's proposal and how to embed it into UR-TWG's efforts. Conducting a qualitative and quantitative study in order to undertake evidence-based advocacy, prioritize urban issues to engage with, and triangulate it with the persisting issues we already know.
- Discussing a tentative work plan consisting of 3 phases (please see presentation).

Some of the key points of discussion in between/following the presentation are listed below:

- JICA: What is the ownership of NRA? Will this be a knowledge-generating platform or will we come up with concrete strategies? Will NRA participate?
HRRP-- NRA requires support in undertaking urban recovery, and will be involved in the process, which HRRP will coordinate. However NRA will not directly be a part of the UR-TWG. We could request Dr. Chandra to join the group but this will have to be done after we have progressed, after a few meetings.

Structural safety should not be compromised but process-related things like permit and ownership can be relaxed to get things moving.

- Lumanti: Policy and finance are the key hurdles in urban reconstruction. We could invite banks to our group to discuss access to loans. The government increased expectations when they rolled out the 2% interest loans, which soon fizzled out. As a group we can make suggestions on how to make finance more accessible.
Another aspect to address is the permit process. How can we get them to approve designs?
- NSET: We are speaking of safer reconstruction and now the NRA is working in the spirit of wrapping up. We need to decide as a group what spirit are we working on?
- Lumanti: Who are not reconstructing and where are they? NRA data does not include everything.
- We need to package issues at core area/ cultural areas/ district HQs. Because the issues will differ accordingly.
- CRS: Setting a TOR for the UR-TWG is important within the constraints of NRA's timeline. We need to set our priorities, as we understand the scope but not entirely the scale of the issues. We could narrow it down to 3-4 issues; the rest are not excluded but will have to be addressed as we move forward.
- Lumanti: The government should come up with ideas to ease this process in addition to providing tranches. From a local organization perspective, how to attract the donors? Local organizations have a critical role in recovery and need more support.
In addition, local governments have a big role to play and need to be committed. The local government needs to be flexible. NRA is far away; the nearest agency to a beneficiary is the ward office.

- CRS: The TOR could include these aspects under “innovation” and we could find different ways of linking these things together. We need to see where the bottlenecks are and to understand the financial aspects more. Affordable housing isn’t only the cost of the house, but about making the process easier. For example stretching the housing repayment period can be done in different ways.
- NSET: We need to relate out process with NRA’s lifetime. After NRA, the responsibilities will go to ministries, NDRMA and local governments. We need to consider short and long term.
- CRS: Use this as an opportunity to put people on the pathway to recovery, even beyond the period of NRA. Some processes will move into the development side.
- Lumanti: Organizations need to continue even after NRA. How will this process continue? We need to ensure that the qualitative and quantitative study we undertake has a larger purpose. NRA should not use our work here for just a guideline for their national workshop.
- JICA: POs already know qualitative issues. Suggests going for quantitative and qualitative information from POs. If the central level goes to the people after 4.5 years, it is already late. They should go with a fixed agenda and some prescription, else it will be a blame game.
- CRS: This could be a good opportunity to seek qualitative data from the local level consultations and use it for cross-referencing.
- Lumanti: It would be useful to know more about NRA’s funds, existing and spent, for housing, livelihood infrastructure etc. as it will help us develop more informed strategies.
- KMC: Each ward should have 1 personnel dedicated only to issues of reconstruction as there are none at present. Municipality is more focused on development rather than reconstruction.

Some cases shared by POs:

- JICA: In places like Mahalaxmi and Gorkha, there aren’t enough human resources to assist in the permit process and the reconstruction is stuck at the permit stage
- Lumanti: There are high cases on non-compliance in Lalitpur, wherein illegal storeys are added after receiving the last tranche. There is a need for policies on safer reconstruction.

- Lumanti: In Khokana ward 21, clearing debris is a huge issue. Lumanti supported the process with a grant. The beneficiaries added their own funds and the debris was collectively cleared. Another issue is lack of land documents.
- Lumanti: In Bungmati we partnered with 5th year architecture students and held a 7-day design workshop. 97 families participated, and the biggest issue was the plot size of the site did not match that of cadastral map for most of them. Matching of the plot size and the cadastral map is one of the prerequisites for building approval. We then had a chance to sit with this dataset with the ward officials. This was an effective process of collecting qualitative data.
- NSET: Under the multi-ownership guideline, 58 houses out 338 houses in Dolakha are being rebuilt. A Project Implementation Unit (PIU) is being set up by the municipality and will be supported by NSET architects and engineers. Our STA package in Dolakha was to contribute drawings. We need to redesign a separate STA for urban areas.
- KMC: In KMC, one of the biggest issues is that of multiple/joint ownership of beneficiaries and thus family disputes.

Steps forward

HRRP to draft TOR

Create Google Drive folder for all UR-TWG files

Weekly meeting (at least in the beginning. Later on fortnightly): next meeting on 20th November 2019

Members To-Dos

Survey on prioritizing issues

Editing/adding to the list of issues (as suggested edits)

Add relevant documents on urban recovery to the Google Drive Folder

Housing Recovery and Reconstruction Platform(HRRP)
Urban Reconstruction Technical Working Group

Date: 13 November, 2019

Venue: HRRP Office, Jwagal, Lalitpur

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